History Notes

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A. Background

In April 2022, the Policy, Training, and Cooperative Programs division began to include history notes in authority records for new and revised subject headings. For headings first established since April 2022, the note indicates the month and year in which the heading was established. For headings established before that date and revised since, the note indicates at a minimum the immediately former heading and the current heading, along with the month and year in which the heading was revised. Information about earlier versions of the heading may also be present if the information is readily available. The note is coded in MARC 21 field 688.

This instruction sheet provides guidelines on the use and format of history notes.

B. Recent revisions

2026-07: Updated template. Sections F.2.e-F.2.g added.

C. Definitions

History notes: A history note documents the date on which the heading was first approved and any subsequent changes to the heading. It does not document changes to other parts of the record, including references, scope notes, source citations, etc.

D. General rule

D.1. Number of history notes

Include only one history note in each authority record, and do not delete information from a note that already exists. Revise the history note as necessary by adding information to it, separating the pieces of information with a period.

E. New headings

History notes are generated automatically when proposals for new headings are approved. The note reflects the month and year in which the heading was added to LCSH (which may not be the same month in which the proposal appeared on a tentative list). The name of the month is spelled out in full. The following format is used.

Model:

```
688 ## $a Established [month] [year].
```

Example:

```
688 ## $a Established March 2022.
```

F. Revisions to headings

F.1. General rule

When a heading is revised and a “former heading” reference is provided, policy specialists provide a note that indicates the way in which the heading was changed and the month and year in which the change occurred. The field ends with a period. The following format is used.

Model:

```
688 ## $a Heading changed from [former heading] to [current heading] in
       [month] [year].
```

If a history note already exists in the record, new information is appended to it. Separate the elements of information with a period.

Examples:

```
150 ## $a Dramatic music $z Southeast Asia
450 ## $w nne $a Dramatic music $z Asia, Southeastern
688 ## $a Established January 2002. Heading changed from Dramatic music--
       Asia, Southeastern to Dramatic music--Southeast Asia in August 2005.
```

```
150 ## Pijanec (North Macedonia and Bulgaria)
450 ## $w nne $a Pijanec (Macedonia)
450 ## $w nne $a Pijanec (Macedonia and Bulgaria)
688 ## $a Established March 1988. Heading changed from Pijanec (Macedonia)
       to Pijane (Macedonia and Bulgaria) in March 1990. Heading changed
       from Pijanec (Macedonia and Bulgaria) to Pijanec (North Macedonia and
       Bulgaria) in June 2019.
```

F.2. Special situations

F.2.a. Subdivided headings

Include a history note in the subdivided heading if the subdivision is being revised. If the only change is to the main heading, the history note in the record for the main heading covers the change.

Examples:

```
150 ## $a Automatic test equipment
450 ## $w nne $a Automatic checkout equipment
688 ## $a Heading changed from Automatic checkout equipment to Automatic
       test equipment in June 2004.
```

```
150 ## $a Automatic test equipment $x Buffer stocks
```

[change does not affect the subdivision, so a 688 field is not added or revised]

```
150 ## $a Church music $x Hutterian Brethren
450 ## $w nne $a Church music $x Hutterite Brethren
688 ## Heading changed from Church music--Hutterite Brethren to Church
       music—Hutterian Brethren in December 2021.
```

[change affects the subdivision]

F.2.b. Phrase headings based on other headings

Include a history note in the phrase heading.

Examples:

```
150 ## $a Automatic test equipment industry
450 ## $w nne $a Automatic checkout equipment industry
688 ## $a Heading changed from Automatic checkout equipment industry to
       Automatic test equipment industry in June 2004.
```

F.2.c. Heading splits

Include a history note when a single heading is split into two or more headings. Follow the general format provided in sec. E.1, giving the former heading as well as all of the headings into which it was split.

Examples:

```
010 ## $a $a sh2020006293 $z sh2005001761
150 ## $a Northern Idaho ground squirrel
450 ## $w nne $a Idaho ground squirrel
688 ## $a Heading changed from Idaho ground squirrel to Northern Idaho
       ground squirrel and Southern Idaho ground squirrel in September 2020.


010 ## $a sh2020006294 $z sh2005001761
150 ## $a Southern Idaho ground squirrel
450 ## $w nne $a Idaho ground squirrel
688 ## $a Heading changed from Idaho ground squirrel to Northern Idaho
       ground squirrel and Southern Idaho ground squirrel in September 2020.
```

F.2.d. Heading mergers

Include a history note when two or more headings are merged into a single heading. Follow the general format provided in sec. E.1, giving the former headings as well as the heading into which they were merged.

Example:

```
010 ## $a sh 85000871 $z sh 85000704 $z sh 85098104
150 ## $a Pteridaceae
450 ## $w nne $a Actiniopteridaceae
450 ## $w nne $a Adiantaceae
450 ## $w nne $a Parkeriaceae
```

```
688 ## $a Heading changed from Actiniopteridaceae, Adiantaceae, and
       Parkeriaceae to Pteridaceae in May 2024.
```

F.2.e. Change in diacritics

Include a history note when a diacritic is added to or removed from a heading.

Example:

```
150 ## $a Māori language
688 ## $a Heading changed from Maori language to Māori language in December
       2022.
```

F.2.f. Name headings replaced by subject headings

If the heading string changed, exclusive of the coding, provide a history note that describes the change. Follow the format described in sec. E.1.

Example:

```
010 ## $a sh2021008320 $z nb2012011789
151 ## $a Inu Jima (Okayama-ken, Japan)
688 ## $a Heading changed from Inu-shima (Japan) to Inu Jima (Okayama-ken,
       Japan) in December 2021.
```

If the heading string did not change, do not provide a history note.

Example:

```
010 ## $a sh 95006691 $z n  93095889
150 ## $a International Women's Day
```

[heading string did not change]

F.2.g. Closing dates added

If a closing date is added to an existing heading, add a history note but do not add the Used For reference, per H 193.

Example:

```
010 ## $a sh2023001474
150 ## $a COVID-19 Pandemic, 2020-2023, in literature
688 $a Established October 2023. Heading changed from COVID-19 Pandemic,
       2020- , in literature to COVID-19 Pandemic, 2020-2023, in literature
       in February 2026.
```

[closing date added]

F.2.h. Geographic name changed

If a geographic name changes in the name authority file, a history note is not required for changes when the geographic name is the foundation of the heading. If the geographic name is used as a geographic subdivision or as a qualifier, add the history note.

Example:

Congo (Democratic Republic) was changed to Democratic Republic of the Congo in the name authority file.

```
010 ## $a sh 85149554
151 ## $a Democratic Republic of the Congo $x Antiquities
```

[no 688 required]

```
010 ## $a sh 85045414
150 ## $a Ethnology $z Democratic Republic of the Congo
688 ## $a Heading changed from Ethnology--Congo (Democratic Republic) to
       Ethnology--Democratic Republic of the Congo in August 2026.
```

```
010 ## $a sh 89000448
151 ## $a Katongo Site (Democratic Republic of the Congo)
688 ## $a Heading changed from Katongo Site (Congo) to Katongo Site
       (Democratic Republic of the Congo) in August 2026.
```

G. Adding history notes retrospectively

Policy specialists may add or revise history notes when references, scope notes, classification numbers, etc., are edited and information on the history of the heading is readily available, but the note should indicate only the date on which the heading (not a reference, etc.) was established and/or changed.

History notes may also be added or revised by policy specialists when research into the heading is undertaken for another reason (e.g., in response to a query).

History notes added retrospectively may be vague about the dates. Provide specific months and years whenever possible, but do not undertake extensive or time-consuming research only to provide that information. Use judgment when formatting the note; the goal is to document each change as clearly as possible.

Examples:

```
150 ## $a Railroad cars $x Axles
450 ## $w nne $a Car axles
```

```
688 ## $a Heading changed from Car axles to Railroad cars–Axles in October
       2006.
```

[Date on which the heading Car axles was approved was not available, but date of heading change was]

```
110 2# $a Casa Aguayo (Puebla de Zaragoza, Mexico)

410 2# $w nne $a Casa Aguayo (Pueblo, Mexico)

688 ## $a Established June 2002. Heading changed from Casa Aguayo (Pueblo,
       Mexico) to Casa Aguayo (Pueblo de Zaragoza, Mexico) in July 2012.
```

[Dates of original inclusion and revision were both readily available]

```
150 ## $a Ndebele language (Zimbabwe)

450 ## $w nne $a Ndebele language (Rhodesia)

450 ## $w nne $a Tebele language

688 ## $a Heading changed from Ndebele language (Rhodesia) to Ndebele
       language (Zimbabwe) in 1983. It was originally Tebele language.
```

[Date of approval of Tebele language was not readily available, and neither was the date of the change from Tebele language to Ndebele language (Rhodesia). The year Ndebele language (Rhodesia) was changed to Ndebele language (Zimbabwe) was available in the 1983 quarterly Supplement to LC Subject Headings]

Revision history

2026-07: Updated template. Sections F.2.e-F.2.g added.